



Università
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di Perugia



Beyond Fragmentation? Contemporary Forms of Belonging Between Ideology and Narrative

Annual Conference of the Italian Association of Political Communication (AssoComPol)

Perugia, 10-12 December 2026

Department of Political Science | University of Perugia

Department of International Human and Social Sciences | University for Foreigners of Perugia

In recent years, the social sciences have explored the process of fragmentation of the cultural field and of public discourse, associated with polarization, distrust in institutions, and with the crisis of mediating functions, including those of parties and journalism. However, it seems that contemporary society, facing the contradictions and uncertainties of the global context, is looking for pathways of renewed belonging defined by political-cultural and affective affinities. Such tendency may be helped by the sharing practices in the hybrid media environments. Rather than as elements of disintegration, such processes can be investigated as new forms of belonging, capable of producing recognition, connection, and coordination, and therefore as processes of re-aggregation.

This perspective does not exclude dynamics of conflict or perceived incompatibility. Values and interpretations are redefined through new criteria of legitimation to express strategies of reaction to contemporary complexity or resilience in response to global crises.

Within this tendency, a relevant process seems to be shaped by a shift toward pre-political ideas, practices, and experiences rooted in everyday life, lifestyles, local contexts, and cultural consumption. This implies a personalization of social participation, often assuming a collective dimension. The perception of community ties is increasingly important, so that identities and sub-cultures acquire higher relevance. These forms of belonging redefine the way influence and leadership are enacted and become able to aggregate meanings, exploiting the multiple possibilities offered by social and media arenas, also linking different contexts and environments.

Such processes call for a closer examination of language, understood not simply as word or image, but as a more general device for identity construction, legitimation, and agency. Languages are practiced as markers of belonging and shared feelings, and as resources for defining group boundaries. The search for a common ground appears capable of producing or revitalizing various types of community which, in addition to internal cohesion, are oriented toward participation in the public sphere. They can be seen as nodes in socio-cultural networks whose cohesion is played out within the interaction between social territories and media environments, including the digital platforms and artificial intelligence systems, which help shape visibility, social relationships, access to content, and may foster processes of symbolic aggregation.



The conference therefore welcomes theoretical and empirical contributions on the following themes:

- Transformations in political cultures and in party organizations.
- The role of values in political cultures and political communication.
- Pre-political dimensions of citizenship, agency, and participation.
- The affective dimension of political cultures and political communication.
- Changes in political and government communication strategies, election campaigns, and voting in national and international contexts.
- Emerging political subcultures.
- Symbolic content and communicative forms of online communities.
- Journalists and journalism as aggregators of communities.
- Forms and actors of an alternative news ecosystem.
- Readership, news use, and forms of community around informational content.
- Disinformation, polarization, and incivility in contemporary forms of political and cultural belonging.
- Redefinition of the public agenda in the European space.
- Methodological proposals, approaches and techniques for the analysis of the cultural transformation.
- Strategies and experiences of connection among movements and subcultural entities.
- Innovative and/or alternative experiences of political-cultural and volunteer associations.
- Local movements, unconventional movements and association networks.
- Local belonging as political cultures.
- Cultural consumption and art experiences as forms of civic engagement.
- The technological infrastructure of political participation.
- Platforms and social media as environments of political empowerment and civic engagement.
- Social understanding of technology, of the opportunities and risks linked to artificial intelligence.

Paper proposals must include:

- Title
- Author(s), including the affiliation and institutional email address of each author
- Extended abstract (5000 characters, space included)
- References
- 3 keywords

The proposal must explicitly indicate whether the paper should be considered, after the conference, for publication in the journal “Comunicazione Politica”. If two or more proposals receive the same evaluation score by the referees, priority will be given to those whose authors have indicated their interest in being considered for publication in “Comunicazione Politica” after the conference.

Please note: indicating an interest in having the contribution considered by ComPol – Comunicazione Politica will allow the journal’s Editorial Board to follow the presentation of the paper during the conference. However, this does not replace the formal submission procedure,



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which must be completed through the journal's website, nor does it imply the automatic acceptance of the manuscript.

Useful information on how to write an abstract for AssoComPol conferences is available in the "Abstract Instructions" section of the AssoComPol website:

<https://www.compol.it/eventi/convegno/convegno-2026/>

Relevant deadlines:

- Deadline for uploading proposals on the website <https://compol.confnow.eu/>: **16 September 2026**
- Notification of acceptance: **10-12 October 2026**
- Full papers must be uploaded by **30 November 2026** to the [conference paper room](#) (accessible after login).

Scientific Committee: Cristopher Cepernich, Matteo Gerli, Paolo Mancini, Rita Marchetti, Rolando Marini, Giampietro Mazzoleni, Marco Mazzoni, Augusto Valeriani.

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